KENTUCKY COMMUNITY & TECHNICAL COLLEGE SYSTEM

ESSENTIAL SKILL 8 · FROM YOUR COLLEAGUES

Community Advocacy Campaign

Communication · Persuasive Public Speaking

Teams pick a community issue, research it from several sides, and deliver an 8–10 minute public awareness presentation with a call to action. The six-week project pairs communication SLOs 2 and 3 with Essential Skill 8.

Contributed by **Sherri Basil** and adapted with permission for *Designing Collaboration That Works*, the KCTCS faculty guide to Essential Skill 8. Student-facing sections are written to copy into Blackboard. Draft for review, in-house resource.

COURSE
Communication (SLOs 2 and 3)

LENGTH
Six weeks

TEAM SIZE
Set by instructor

FORMAT
Online or hybrid, in Blackboard Ultra

FINAL PRODUCT
8–10 minute team presentation, plus an individual reflection

Closest level in the guide: **Level 4 · Sustained**

1 · Quick | 2 · Structured | 3 · Coordinated | **4 · Sustained**

In this packet

1. About the Project FOR FACULTY
2. Blackboard Collaboration Components FOR FACULTY
3. The Assignment FOR STUDENTS
4. Week 1 Discussion: Community Issues That Matter FOR STUDENTS
5. Collaboration Survey (Week 1) FOR STUDENTS
6. Week 2: Team Formation and Planning FOR STUDENTS

About the Project

FOR FACULTY

Project Summary

As part of the Kentucky Graduate Profile, students are expected to develop the knowledge and skills needed to communicate effectively and work collaboratively in academic, civic, and professional settings. In this project, students will work in teams to identify a community issue, research multiple perspectives, develop an advocacy campaign, and present a persuasive public awareness presentation designed to educate and influence a specific audience.

Unlike a traditional speech assignment where students focus primarily on delivery, this project requires students to:

- Research an authentic issue
- Work through team dynamics
- Practice workplace communication
- Create audience-centered messages
- Deliver a persuasive presentation
- Develop a documented Essential Skill

Most importantly, students can clearly articulate not only what they learned in Communication, but also how they developed a workforce-ready skill that is part of the Kentucky Graduate Profile: "the ability to collaborate and work effectively in teams." This makes the Essential Skill visible, measurable, and meaningful rather than simply another assignment.

This project intentionally integrates:

Communication Course Outcomes

- **SLO 2:** Develop messages appropriate for audience, purpose, and channel in public speaking.
- **SLO 3:** Construct logically organized outlines for informative and persuasive speeches.

Kentucky Essential Skill 8

Collaborate and Work in Teams

Students will demonstrate teamwork by:

- Sharing responsibilities
- Participating in decision-making
- Providing constructive feedback
- Managing group challenges professionally
- Working together toward a common goal

Blackboard Collaboration Components

FOR FACULTY

Students complete:

Team Roles

Examples:

- Project Manager
- Research Lead
- Content Designer
- Visual Designer
- Presenter

Team Expectations

- Meeting frequency
- Communication norms
- Conflict resolution procedures

Shared Goals

- Project deadlines
- Quality expectations

Week 1

Discussion Board

"What community issue matters most to you and why?"

Students apply communication concepts and identify potential project topics.

Week 2

Team Formation and Planning

Students:

- Form groups
- Analyze audience needs
- Create Team Charter
- Assign responsibilities

Week 3

Research and Audience Analysis

Students:

- Gather evidence
- Identify audience characteristics
- Analyze persuasive strategies

Week 4

Campaign Design

Students:

- Create presentation outline
- Develop visuals
- Organize content

Week 5

Peer Review

Students evaluate:

- Presentation effectiveness
- Evidence quality
- Audience appeal
- Team collaboration

Week 6

Final Presentation

Students deliver:

- Public awareness presentation
- Reflection on teamwork experience

Individual Reflection

After completing the presentation, each student will submit a reflection addressing:

Communication

How did your team adapt its message for the intended audience?

Collaboration

How did you contribute to team success?

Professional Growth

What teamwork skills did you strengthen during this project?

Graduate Profile Question

How did this project help you understand ways to work in teams and collaborate on a specific project? (Essential Skill 8 from the Kentucky Graduate Profile)

Setting up groups

For step-by-step setup, see 8.1 Blackboard and 8.2 Microsoft Teams in the Skill 8 guide, or Blackboard's Group Assignments help.

The Assignment

FOR STUDENTS

Real-World Scenario

Imagine your team has been selected by a local organization, college committee, or community group to raise awareness about an issue impacting your community.

Examples may include:

- Student mental health
- Digital citizenship
- Financial literacy
- Food insecurity
- Community volunteerism
- Environmental sustainability
- Workforce readiness
- AI in education
- Voter engagement
- Public health awareness

Your team will design and deliver a public awareness campaign that informs and motivates an audience to take action.

Learning Objectives

By the end of this project, students will be able to:

Apply

Apply communication principles to work effectively in a collaborative team environment.

Analyze

Analyze audience needs, stakeholder perspectives, and community issues.

Evaluate

Evaluate evidence and communication strategies to determine the most effective persuasive approach for a target audience.

Create

Create and deliver a community advocacy presentation supported by research and effective teamwork practices.

Final Deliverable

Team Presentation (8–10 Minutes)

Teams will deliver a persuasive public awareness presentation that includes:

Introduction

- Introduce the issue.
- Establish audience relevance.

Problem Analysis

- Describe the issue.
- Explain why it matters.
- Present supporting evidence.

Proposed Solution

- Recommend realistic actions.
- Explain potential impact.

Call to Action

- Encourage audience involvement.
- Provide specific next steps.

Week 1 Discussion: Community Issues That Matter

FOR STUDENTS

Discussion Board: Community Issues That Matter

Discussion Topic: What Community Issue Matters Most to You and Why?

As part of our project and to strengthen your **Essential Skill 8: Collaborate and Work in Teams**, you will begin by reflecting on issues that affect your community. Understanding the concerns and perspectives of others is an important first step in working together to identify solutions and create positive change.

Initial Post

In a well-developed response (150-250 words), answer the following question:

What community issue matters most to you and why?

Consider issues that affect your school, neighborhood, city, workplace, or society. Examples might include:

- Access to education
- Mental health awareness
- Affordable housing
- Homelessness
- Food insecurity
- Environmental sustainability
- Public safety
- Transportation
- Digital access and technology
- Health care access
- Workforce development

In your response:

1. Identify the community issue that concerns you most.
2. Explain why this issue is important to you personally.
3. Describe how the issue affects individuals or groups within the community.
4. Share one idea that could help address or improve the situation.

Replies to Classmates

Reply to at least **two classmates**. Each response should be at least **75 words** and should:

- Respectfully acknowledge their perspective.
- Identify one point you agree with or found interesting.

- Ask a thoughtful question or suggest an additional idea for addressing the issue.
- Explain how collaboration among community members could help create positive change.

Connection to Essential Skill 8: Collaborate and Work in Teams

This discussion encourages you to:

- Listen to and respect diverse perspectives.
- Engage in constructive dialogue.
- Build on the ideas of others.
- Practice working toward shared solutions to real-world problems.
- Recognize how collaboration contributes to stronger communities.

Grading Criteria

Criteria	Possible Grading Points
Clearly identifies and explains a community issue	25
Demonstrates thoughtful reflection and personal connection	25
Proposes a realistic solution or improvement	20
Meaningfully responds to classmates	20
Demonstrates professionalism and respect	10

Remember: The goal of this discussion is not to convince others that your issue is most important, but to learn from different perspectives and work together to explore possible solutions. Collaboration begins with understanding the experiences and viewpoints of others.

Collaboration Survey (Week 1)

FOR STUDENTS

Directions: This item is designed to help designate teams based on their availability and preferred role in a group.

1. **What is your time zone?**

   ☐ Central ☐ Eastern ☐ Mountain ☐ Pacific

2. **What is your typical availability? (Pick at least one)**

   ☐ Weekday Mornings (9-12) ☐ Afternoons (12 - 4) ☐ Weeknights (after 8 pm)

   ☐ Weekends Only

3. **Preferred Role in a group activity:**

   ☐ Researcher ☐ Writer ☐ Editor ☐ Technology (Graph, PowerPoint, etc.) ☐ Organizer

   ☐ Presenter

Week 2: Team Formation and Planning

FOR STUDENTS

Students:

- Form groups
- Analyze audience needs
- Create Team Charter
- Assign responsibilities

Students Decide Team Roles

Examples:

- Project Manager
- Research Lead
- Content Designer
- Visual Designer
- Presenter

Team Expectations

- Meeting frequency
- Communication norms
- Conflict resolution procedures

Shared Goals

- Project deadlines
- Quality expectations
- The type of finished project